to criss-cross it at numerous places. About a kilometre short of PP-14, another *nala* flowing North to South joins the Galwan River. After crossing this junction, it was relatively easy to go up to PP-14. Just South and East of this junction was a flattish piece of ground which could also be developed into a helipad. Because of the terrain, going to PP-14 was time-consuming and it was difficult to go there and return in a single day. The alternatives were either to establish a temporary observation post (OP) at PP-14, which would have been in violation of protocols or construct a motorable track as far forward as possible, at least till the Nala River Junction. Work on this track had already commenced, including the construction of bridges.

On the Chinese side, their nearest post was Galwan, almost 25 km further East of PP-14. Galwan had been an IA Company post that was captured by the Chinese in the 1962 War. Maj (later Lt Col) Shrikant Sitaram Hasabnis, father of the Hasabnis brothers, had fought here and been taken prisoner of war (PW), and repatriated after seven months in captivity.[19] I had often met Lt Col SS Hasabnis during my school days and had always been impressed by his calmness and simplicity. The PLA did not have any road connectivity towards PP-14 except for a natural surface track and they too were improving this track. It was under these circumstances that the earliest clash of May 2020 had occurred, after which they remained encamped a few kilometres away to the East. The PLA had not only objected to our movements up to PP-14 but in a surprising turn, insisted on patrolling up to the Nala River Junction or 'Estuary' as they called it. This was firmly and categorically denied.

This was the stage when the HMCL meeting was held in the second week of May, in the area of the Junction since it was the only flattish space in that general area. Where one meets is also important, based on who suggests it, as it implies control over

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